

[Return to Search](#)

The Maasai of Matapato

Author(S): Spencer, Paul

Document Type: Book

Original Page: 129

Culture (OWC): [Maasai \(FL12\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Eastern Africa

Field Date: July 1976-September 1977

Coverage Date: Not Specified

Place Coverage: Matapato, Kenya

Section Title(S): WARRIOR PROWESS AND SEXUAL VIRTUE

WARRIOR PROWESS AND SEXUAL VIRTUE

Compared with other moran, the diehards held stricter views on sexual relations. Some of them might be selected by girls as their protectors, and a friendship could develop between them. However, the diehards regarded sexual intercourse as a diversion from their true commitment to warrior prowess and limited their indulgence. They might lead their girls to their forest camp, but in sleeping side by side, they would place a log between them so as to avoid body contact. Part of their scorn for other moran was that like elders, they indulged in regular sexual activity and, worse still, even with married women. In their pure state, diehards claimed that they could even smell out an adulterer when they came from the unpolluted atmosphere of the forest on a visit to the manyata. They aimed to avoid married women altogether.

[554](#)
[Status, Role, And Prestige](#)

[701](#)
[Military Organization](#)

[836](#)
[Premarital Sex Relations](#)

[837](#)
[Extramarital Sex Relations](#)

It is with this in mind that one can appreciate the incongruity of a popular vignette.

Case 28.

Lesempito was a Meto diehard who obtained permission from his forest messmates to visit his father briefly. During his visit, he seduced the wife of a relatively senior elder in her hut. Her husband arrived outside the hut and realising she had company, he called out to ask who it was. At first the adulterer proudly exclaimed: 'I am Lesempito of the diehards'. Then,

[554](#)
[Status, Role, And Prestige](#)

[701](#)
[Military Organization](#)

[837](#)
[Extramarital Sex Relations](#)

as is expected of any moran in such cirmcumstances, his nerve cracked and he implored the elder's mercy.

The joke raises a hilarious laugh. The notion of a diehard who was actually tempted to seduce a married woman, then boasted, and then humbled himself before the husband is triply incongruous. His downfall was complete and he could never be accepted back among the diehards. It was as if he had proudly gone to war, planted his foot firmly on one spot -- and had then run away, as any moran faced with a much older men's anger is expected to do. Even ordinary moran and girls would have despised him: he had 'fallen' (*e-sulari*). Adulterous moran in the past who evaded the elders achieved an ambivalent notoriety among their peers; but those that were caught, including the diehard in the story, were handed over by the elders to the manyata for punishment. They would be tied to a post from morning until late afternoon to be pilloried  130 by all; wives, girls and even boys would be told to spit and snot at them. Even a diehard could not retain his respect after such treatment.

522
Humor

554 Status, Role, And Prestige

558
Downward Mobility

684
Sex And Marital
Offenses

701
Military Organization

837
Extramarital Sex
Relations

Human Relations Area Files

755 Prospect Street

New Haven, CT 06511

General Inquiries:  hraf@yale.edu

Issues and Bugs:  hraf-support@yale.edu

[Terms and Conditions](#) · [Accessibility](#) · [Cookie Policy](#)